Experiment 2: Blacklist Application using ManageEngine Desktop Central

Experiment Goal:

To demonstrate that ManageEngine Endpoint Central's Application Control can act as a centralized "remote commander" that enforces an application blacklist (e.g., blocking `notepad.exe`) on your Windows 11 computer that has the Endpoint Central agent installed and is managed from the central console — without any local configuration on that computer — and to contrast this centralized enforcement model against Windows' built-in AppLocker, which functions as a local "guard" configured on or near each machine.

What this Lab work Proves:

Point from File	How the Lab Demonstrates It
"Centralized Management"	You issue the block instruction from the Endpoint Central web console, not from the Windows 11 machine.
"Precise Blocking"	You specify a program like Notepad in a blocklist; once deployed, the underlying driver intercepts the launch and it fails.
"Applicable Scope"	The target is a local `.exe`/`.msi` desktop application (Notepad), not a web app.
"Remote Commander vs. Local Guard"	The lab shows one console commanding enforcement on your Windows 11 computer, whereas AppLocker would require local/Group Policy configuration.

How This Lab Differs from AppLocker:

Dimension	This Lab (Endpoint Central Application Control)	AppLocker (Built-in)
Management Method	Centralized remote management — configure in the web console and push automatically to computers.	Local/Group Policy management — configure separately on each computer or via AD domain group policy.
Applicable Scope	Suitable for multiple computers in enterprises, with unified policy management and reporting.	Suitable for a single computer or environments with an existing AD domain.

Rule Richness	Very rich — trusted vendors, product names, verified executables, file hashes, folder paths, and more.	Relatively basic — mainly publisher, path, and file hash.
Additional Features	Integrated Endpoint Privilege Management (standard users can run specific programs with admin privileges) and other advanced features.	Focuses solely on application execution control; no privilege management.

In simple terms: If you only want to block a program on your own computer, AppLocker or local Group Policy is simplest. But this lab demonstrates the enterprise scenario — **centrally managing a batch of computers with richer rule systems (e.g., blocking by vendor)** — which is what Endpoint Central's Application Control is built for.

Phase 1: Get Your Free Trial

ManageEngine Endpoint Central offers a **30-day free trial** with unlimited endpoints, giving you access to all features including Application Control .

Choose Your Edition: Cloud (SaaS): Faster to set up, no server installation needed.

Sign Up for Cloud:

1. Go to the Endpoint Central free trial page: https://endpointcentral.manageengine.com/
2. Click "Free Sign Up" for Endpoint Central Cloud.
3. Fill in the required information and create your account.
4. After signup, you'll receive an email to activate your account. Click the verification link, set your password, and you'll be logged in.

Phase 2: Install the Agent on Your Test Computer

The agent is required on every computer you want to manage:

1. In the console, go to **Agent** → **Computers**.
2. Click **Download Agent** and select the Windows agent.
3. Run the downloaded `.exe` file on your test computer as Administrator.
4. Follow the wizard to complete installation. No reboot is required.

Phase 3: Create Your Blocklist

Now you define what applications to block. To avoid accidentally blocking critical system programs, it's recommended to use **Notepad (notepad.exe)** as your first test target. In this experiment, I created a Word file with the name Testapp, and then I changed the file extension to .exe.

1. Navigate to **Application Control → Application Groups** .
2. Click **Create Blocklist** and select **Windows** as the target OS.
3. Give your blocklist a name (e.g., "Test Blacklist").
4. **Select Applications Using Filters**: You can use filters like **Product Name** (e.g., `notepad.exe`), **Trusted Vendors**, **File Hash**, or **Folder Path**. In this experiment, I selected 'File Hash' and obtained its hash value by running PowerShell as an administrator, then applied the following command:
   `Get-FileHash "C:\Users\DEEL\OneDrive\Desktop\Testapp.exe"`
   Then, in the 'Test Blacklist' blocklist, we selected 'File Hash' as the filter rule, named the **executable** file, pasted the correct hash value, and saved it. At this point, the step of 'selecting applications using filters' was completed.
5. Click **Create** to save the group.

Phase 4: Deploy the Policy

The blocklist is not active until you deploy it.

1. Navigate to **Application Control → Deploy Policy** .
2. **Create a New Custom Group** containing your test computer.
3. In the **Associate Group interface**, click **'New Custom Group'**, name the group, and select **'Static'** for the category. Then, choose **'Assign Manually'** for the membership, add your computer from the available computers list, and click **'Create Group'**. After this, get back to the **Associate Group** interface and associate the **Custom Group to be associated** and the **Application Group(s) Associated**.
4. **Choose Enforcement Mode**:

- **Audit Mode**: For safe testing. Blocked apps will still run but attempts are logged .
- **Strict Mode**: For full enforcement. Blocked apps will not run .

5. Click **Deploy**.

Phase 5: Verify the Results

1. Run Testapp.exe on the Windows 11 computer.
2. Receive the prompt: "This app cannot be run on your machine" — confirming the block was enforced.
3. Check Systems → Dell-5320 — Compliance Status showed "Policy Up to Date".
4. Check the custom group deployment status — showed "Deployed Successfully".

Phase 6: Clean Up

To stop the experiment, simply delete the deployment policy or remove the test computer from the associated Custom Group. The change will sync on the next refresh cycle .